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Determining What Individual SUS Scores Mean: Adding an Adjective Rating Scale

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ABSTRACT

The System Usability Scale (SUS) is an inexpensive, yet effective tool for assessing the usability of a product, including Web sites, cell phones, interactive voice response systems, TV applications, and more. It provides an easy-to-understand score from 0 (negative) to 100 (positive). While a 100-point scale is intuitive in many respects and allows for relative judgments, information describing how the numeric score translates into an absolute judgment of usability is not known. To help answer that question, a seven-point adjective-anchored Likert scale was added as an eleventh question to nearly 1,000 SUS surveys. Results show that the Likert scale scores correlate extremely well with the SUS scores ($r=0.822$). The addition of the adjective rating scale to the SUS may help practitioners interpret individual SUS scores and aid in explaining the results to non-human factors professionals.

DESCRIPTIVE STATISTICS BY ADJECTIVE RATING (p. 118, Table 3)

Sample size N = 959 surveys:

- Worst Imaginable: Count = 4, Mean SUS = 12.5, SD = 13.1
- Awful: Count = 22, Mean SUS = 20.3, SD = 11.3
- Poor: Count = 72, Mean SUS = 35.7, SD = 12.6
- OK: Count = 211, Mean SUS = 50.9, SD = 13.8
- Good: Count = 345, Mean SUS = 71.4, SD = 11.6
- Excellent: Count = 289, Mean SUS = 85.5, SD = 10.4
- Best Imaginable: Count = 16, Mean SUS = 90.9, SD = 13.4

ACCEPTABILITY RANGES & SCHOOL GRADING SCALE (p. 120-121, Figure 4)

Comparison of adjective ratings, acceptability scores, and school grading scales in relation to the average SUS score:

- Acceptability Ranges:

* Not Acceptable: 0 to 50

* Marginal (Low Marginal 50 to ~63, High Marginal ~63 to 70)

* Acceptable: 70 to 100

- Grade Scale:

* Grade F: 0 to ~60

* Grade D: ~60 to 70

* Grade C: 70 to 80

* Grade B: 80 to 90

* Grade A: 90 to 100